DATA 620 Project 1: Centrality in a Network of Criminal Organizations

Kerwin Charles

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1 DATA 620 – Project 1: Centrality in a Network of Criminal Organizations

- **Author:** Kerwin Charles
- **Dataset:** CRIMENET, a knowledge graph of relationships between criminal organizations (https://github.com/alvarofrancomartins/CRIMENET)

1.1 Introduction

For this project I wanted to stay with the fraud and organized crime theme from this week's discussion. In the discussion, the idea that kept coming up was that a single fraudulent account or company can look normal on its own, and it's the connections that give it away. CRIMENET lets me look at the same idea one level up: instead of accounts or companies, the nodes are criminal organizations (cartels, mafias, gangs, motorcycle clubs) and the edges are documented relationships between them.

My question: do criminal organizations from different parts of the world hold different positions in the network of criminal cooperation? I measure position two ways:

- **Degree centrality**, which counts how many partners an organization has.
- **Eigenvector centrality**, which rewards being connected to partners that are themselves well connected. An organization can have a modest number of partners and still score high if those partners sit at the center of the network.

The categorical variable is each organization's **region of origin**. As a second, simpler comparison, I also compare **active** and **defunct** organizations.

Outline

1. The data and the choices I made
2. Loading the data and building the cooperation network
3. Exploring the network: connectivity, group sizes and ties between regions
4. Degree and eigenvector centrality, and who is most central
5. Comparing the regions, with statistical tests
6. Active vs. defunct organizations
7. Seeing the network, findings and limitations

1.2 The data

CRIMENET was built by Alvaro Franco Martins from Wikipedia articles in English, Italian, Portuguese and Spanish. An LLM pipeline read 1,418 articles and pulled out every criminal organization they mention and every relationship between two organizations. Each relationship keeps the sentence from Wikipedia that supports it, so any edge can be checked against its source. The data is released under the MIT license.

Nodes are organizations. Each organization that has its own Wikipedia article is "profiled": it has a country of origin, an activity period and a flag for whether it is defunct. Organizations that only show up as a mention inside someone else's article are kept in the dataset too, but their country is left empty.

Edges come in three types:

Type	Meaning
cooperation	the two organizations work together: alliances, joint operations, supplying or laundering for each other
conflict	the two organizations work against each other: wars, killings, rivalries
other	structural ties (faction, splinter group, successor) or a vague "linked to"

Two choices I made, and why

1. **Cooperation edges only.** Mixing alliances and wars in one network would make centrality hard to interpret. A cartel with 30 enemies would look just as "central" as one with 30 allies. Keeping one type of relationship means every edge means the same thing: "these two organizations work together."
2. **Profiled organizations only.** The project needs a category for every node, and mention-only organizations have no country. Keeping only profiled organizations means every node has a region. The trade-off is that ties to mention-only organizations are dropped, so some degrees are lower than they would be in the full graph.

The edges are undirected. When several Wikipedia sentences describe the same pair of organizations working together, I keep one edge and store the number of sentences as `supporting_statements`.

```
Python 3.11.10 | networkx 3.6.1 | pandas 3.0.3 | libraries loaded
```

1.3 Loading the data

The whole dataset is one JSON file in the CRIMENET GitHub repository. The code downloads it the first time it runs and reads the saved copy after that.

```
Organizations in CRIMENET : 4,504
Relationships in CRIMENET : 10,935
Relationship types        : {'other': 2297, 'cooperation': 4907, 'conflict':
3731}
```

```
{'standard_name': "'Ndrangheta", 'country': 'Italy', 'time_period': '19th
century-present', 'is_defunct': False, 'profiled': True}

'Ndrangheta <-> American Mafia
Evidence: These Italian crime groups frequently collaborate with the Italian-
American Mafia, which is itself an offshoot of the Sicilian Mafia.
```

1.3.1 Region of origin

CRIMENET stores a country of origin for each profiled organization. Most countries only have a handful of organizations, which is too few to compare, so I grouped countries into five regions. "Latin America" includes Mexico, Central America and the Caribbean. Turkey and the Middle East are grouped with Africa, and Pakistan and Afghanistan with Asia-Pacific. These are judgement calls, but they only affect a few organizations.

1.4 Building the cooperation network

```
Profiled organizations             : 1,032
… with at least one cooperation tie: 722
Cooperation ties between them      : 1,803
Organizations without a region     : 0
```

1.5 Exploring the network

1.5.1 Is the network fully connected?

```
Separate groups (components) : 24
Sizes of the 6 largest       : [659, 12, 5, 4, 4, 2]
Largest group                : 659 organizations, 1752 ties
Organizations outside it     : 63
Their regions                : {'Europe': 21, 'North America': 34, 'Latin
America': 2, 'Asia-Pacific': 5, 'Middle East & Africa': 1}
```

The network is **not** fully connected. Most organizations (659) belong to one large group, and the rest sit in 23 small groups, the biggest with only 12 members. Eigenvector centrality only makes sense inside a connected network, so from here on I analyze the **largest group of 659 organizations** for both measures. That way degree and eigenvector centrality are calculated on exactly the same organizations.

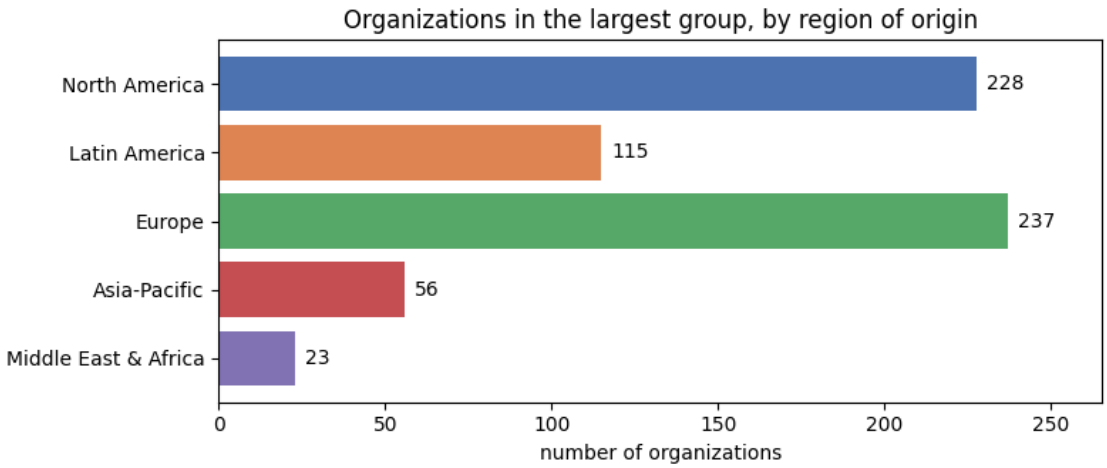
```
                     organizations
region
North America                  228
Latin America                  115
Europe                         237
Asia-Pacific                    56
Middle East & Africa            23
```

```
         organizations
status
Active             508
```

```
Defunct            136
Unknown             15
```

```
Top 8 countries:
```

```
               count
country
United States    196
Italy            195
Mexico            50
Canada            32
Colombia          25
Japan             21
Brazil            18
Australia          9
```



The groups are uneven. Europe and North America each have more than 220 organizations, while the Middle East & Africa has only 23. Europe is mostly Italy: the Italian mafias are split into many separate family units ('ndrine, clans), and each one is its own node. The United States is the same story for the American Mafia families and the motorcycle clubs.

1.5.2 Do organizations cooperate across regions?

Before comparing groups, it's worth checking that ties actually cross between them. If every region only cooperated with itself, the regions would be separate networks rather than groups within one network.

```
Ties within the same region : 1501 of 1752 (86%)
Region assortativity        : 0.80
```

```
                  N. Am.  Lat. Am.  Europe  Asia-Pac.  ME & Afr.
North America        551        61      63         34          3
Latin America         61       302      45         10          8
Europe                63        45     557          4          9
```

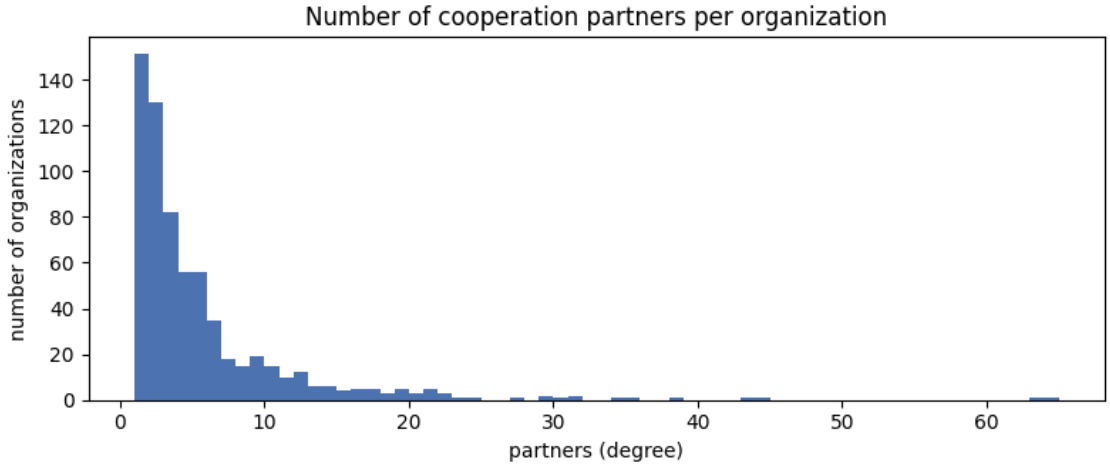
Asia-Pacific	34	10	4	61	14
Middle East & Africa	3	8	9	14	30

	share of ties to other regions
North America	0.13
Latin America	0.17
Europe	0.10
Asia-Pacific	0.34
Middle East & Africa	0.36

Ties do cross regions, but most cooperation stays close to home: 86% of ties connect two organizations from the same region, and the assortativity of 0.80 confirms that strong pull. The regions differ, though. About a third of the ties of Asia-Pacific and Middle Eastern & African organizations go to another region, compared with 17% for Latin America, 13% for North America and only 10% for Europe.

1.5.3 How are partners distributed?

count	659.00
mean	5.32
std	6.71
min	1.00
25%	2.00
50%	3.00
75%	6.00
max	64.00



The distribution is very skewed. The median organization has 3 partners, but a few have more than 40. That skew is the reason I use rank-based tests (Kruskal–Wallis and Mann–Whitney) alongside the t-test later on: the t-test compares means, and a few huge hubs can pull a mean around.

1.6 Degree and eigenvector centrality

	degree_centrality	eigenvector_centrality
count	659.0000	659.0000
mean	0.0081	0.0205
std	0.0102	0.0332
min	0.0015	0.0000
25%	0.0030	0.0019
50%	0.0046	0.0093
75%	0.0091	0.0224
max	0.0973	0.2992

Degree centrality is the number of partners divided by the 658 other organizations, so a score of 0.01 means about 1% of the network. Eigenvector centrality is scaled by networkx so that the squared scores add up to 1, which means the numbers are only meaningful relative to each other. Both measures are heavily skewed, with medians far below the maximums.

1.7 Who is most central?

A top 5 is too short to learn much, especially when both measures give the same list. So I list the **top 20** for each measure side by side and look at where the two lists differ.

Top 20 by degree centrality

	organization	region	partners	score
1	Hells Angels Motorcycle Club	North America	64	0.0973
2	Sinaloa Cartel	Latin America	63	0.0957
3	'Ndrangheta	Europe	44	0.0669
4	American Mafia	North America	43	0.0653
5	Cártel de Jalisco Nueva Gene…	Latin America	38	0.0578
6	Gambino crime family	North America	35	0.0532
7	Mexican Mafia	North America	34	0.0517
8	Gulf Cartel	Latin America	31	0.0471
9	Los Zetas	Latin America	31	0.0471
10	Bonanno crime family	North America	30	0.0456
11	Genovese crime family	North America	29	0.0441
12	Chicago Outfit	North America	29	0.0441
13	Camorra	Europe	27	0.0410
14	Commisso 'ndrina	Europe	24	0.0365
15	Crips	North America	23	0.0350
16	Latin Kings	North America	22	0.0334
17	Outlaws Motorcycle Club	North America	22	0.0334
18	Nuova Famiglia	Europe	22	0.0334
19	Juárez Cartel	Latin America	21	0.0319
20	Sicilian Mafia	Europe	21	0.0319

Top 20 by eigenvector centrality

	organization	region	partners	score
1	Sinaloa Cartel	Latin America	63	0.2992

```
2      Hells Angels Motorcycle Club  North America        64  0.2351
3               Gambino crime family  North America        35  0.2041
4                        'Ndrangheta         Europe        44  0.2002
5                   American Mafia  North America        43  0.1833
6             Genovese crime family  North America        29  0.1725
7   Cártel de Jalisco Nueva Gene…  Latin America        38  0.1725
8                       Gulf Cartel  Latin America        31  0.1702
9                         Los Zetas  Latin America        31  0.1605
10                  Mexican Mafia  North America        34  0.1519
11                  Chicago Outfit  North America        29  0.1416
12             Bonanno crime family  North America        30  0.1394
13              Detroit Partnership  North America        20  0.1343
14                   Tijuana Cartel  Latin America        19  0.1296
15         Los Angeles crime family  North America        17  0.1264
16                    Juárez Cartel  Latin America        21  0.1250
17                  Sicilian Mafia         Europe        21  0.1124
18            La Familia Michoacana  Latin America        17  0.1117
19             Buffalo crime family  North America        17  0.1116
20           Cleveland crime family  North America        14  0.1109
```

Organizations in both top 20 lists: 14

In the degree top 20 only (many partners, less central partners):

organization	region	partners	deg rank	eig rank
Camorra	Europe	27	13	22
Commisso 'ndrina	Europe	24	14	39
Crips	North America	23	15	54
Latin Kings	North America	22	16	28
Nuova Famiglia	Europe	22	16	112
Outlaws Motorcycle Club	North America	22	16	33

In the eigenvector top 20 only (fewer partners, but very central ones):

organization	region	partners	deg rank	eig rank
Detroit Partnership	North America	20	24	13
Tijuana Cartel	Latin America	19	27	14
Los Angeles crime family	North America	17	35	15
La Familia Michoacana	Latin America	17	35	18
Buffalo crime family	North America	17	35	19
Cleveland crime family	North America	14	49	20

region	organization	country	first_rank	\
Latin America	Sinaloa Cartel	Mexico	1	
North America	Hells Angels Motorcycle Club	United States	2	
Europe	'Ndrangheta	Italy	4	

```
Middle East & Africa                    Hezbollah        Lebanon          61
Asia-Pacific                               Yakuza          Japan          66
```

```
                     partners
region
Latin America              63
North America              64
Europe                     44
Middle East & Africa       11
Asia-Pacific                7
```

Fourteen of the 20 names are the same in both lists. The Sinaloa Cartel and the Hells Angels are first and second either way, followed by the 'Ndrangheta, the American Mafia and the big Mexican cartels. The differences are where it gets interesting:

- **High degree, lower eigenvector rank:** the Camorra, the Commisso 'ndrina, the Nuova Famiglia, the Crips, the Latin Kings and the Outlaws. They have plenty of partners, but those partners are smaller groups on the edge of the network. Most of the Italian groups here cooperate mainly with other Italian clans.
- **Lower degree, high eigenvector rank:** the Detroit Partnership, the Tijuana Cartel, the Los Angeles, Buffalo and Cleveland crime families and La Familia Michoacana. They don't have the most partners, but their partners are the network's biggest hubs, like the American Mafia and the Sinaloa Cartel. The textbook calls this kind of position a "gray cardinal."

Several organizations tie at 21 partners right at the cut-off for the degree top 20. The notebook breaks ties by eigenvector centrality and then by name, so the lists come out the same every time it runs.

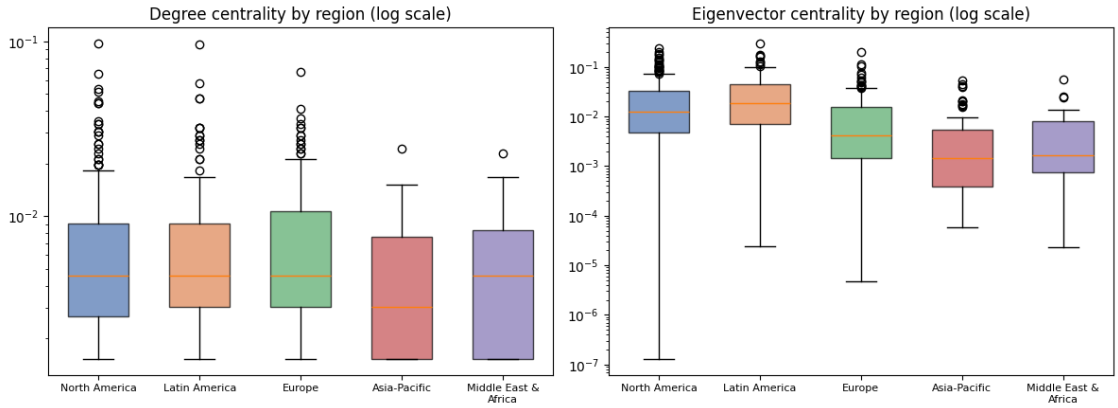
The first-appearance table shows how lopsided influence is. The first European organization (the 'Ndrangheta) shows up at rank 4, but the first organization from the Middle East & Africa (Hezbollah) only appears at rank 61, and the first from Asia-Pacific (the Yakuza) at rank 66.

1.8 Comparing the regions

```
                     orgs  mean partners  median partners  mean degree  mean
eigen  \
region
North America         228         5.5395             3.0       0.0084
0.0271
Latin America         115         6.3304             3.0       0.0096
0.0346
Europe                237         5.2110             3.0       0.0079
0.0117
Asia-Pacific           56         3.2857             2.0       0.0050
0.0070
Middle East & Africa   23         4.0870             3.0       0.0062
0.0077

                     median eigen
```

region	
North America	0.0124
Latin America	0.0184
Europe	0.0041
Asia-Pacific	0.0015
Middle East & Africa	0.0017



1.8.1 Statistical tests

With five groups I use the **Kruskal–Wallis test**, a rank-based version of a one-way ANOVA that doesn't assume normal data. If it finds a difference, I follow up with **Mann–Whitney tests** for each pair of regions, using a Bonferroni correction because there are 10 pairs.

```
degree_centrality        Kruskal-Wallis H =   6.88, p = 0.14
eigenvector_centrality   Kruskal-Wallis H =  93.37, p = 2.5e-19
```

	region A	region B	P(A > B)	p (Bonferroni)	significant
0	North America	Latin America	0.43	0.26	False
1	North America	Europe	0.66	4.3e-08	True
2	North America	Asia-Pacific	0.75	6.7e-08	True
3	North America	Middle East & Africa	0.73	0.003	True
4	Latin America	Europe	0.73	1.4e-11	True
5	Latin America	Asia-Pacific	0.81	3.1e-10	True
6	Latin America	Middle East & Africa	0.79	8.6e-05	True
7	Europe	Asia-Pacific	0.62	0.046	True
8	Europe	Middle East & Africa	0.60	1	False
9	Asia-Pacific	Middle East & Africa	0.47	1	False

1.8.2 Is it just group size?

A fair question is whether a group looks more central simply because it has more members. Here the answer is no. Europe has the most organizations in the network, but its median eigenvector score is about a third of North America's and less than a quarter of Latin America's. Latin America

has half as many organizations as Europe and the highest median. The table below puts the size of each region next to its share of the 50 most central organizations by each measure.

region	share of orgs	degree top 50	eigenvector top 50
North America	35%	38%	56%
Latin America	17%	28%	34%
Europe	36%	30%	10%
Asia-Pacific	8%	2%	0%
Middle East & Africa	3%	2%	0%

1.8.3 The most central organization in each region

region	most partners	highest eigenvector
North America	Hells Angels Motorcycle Club…	Hells Angels Motorcycle Club…
Latin America	Sinaloa Cartel (63)	Sinaloa Cartel (rank 1)
Europe	'Ndrangheta (44)	'Ndrangheta (rank 4)
Asia-Pacific	Yamaguchi-gumi (16)	Yakuza (rank 66)
Middle East & Africa	Al-Qaeda (15)	Hezbollah (rank 61)

1.8.4 How far does cooperation reach from a hub?

One way to see what centrality means in practice is to start from a hub and see how fast you reach the rest of the network. Below I count how many organizations are 1, 2, 3 or more steps away from the most central organization in the Americas (the Sinaloa Cartel) and from the most central Asia-Pacific organization (the Yakuza).

steps away	from Sinaloa Cartel	from Yakuza	Sinaloa, cumulative %	Yakuza, cumulative %
1	63	7	10.0	1.0
2	234	120	45.0	19.0
3	219	280	78.0	
4	115	190	96.0	
5	24	46	100.0	
6	2	14	100.0	
7	1	1	100.0	

```
3                          62.0
4                          91.0
5                          98.0
6                         100.0
7                         100.0
```

Word travels much faster from the hub. Within two steps the Sinaloa Cartel reaches 45% of the network, compared with 19% for the Yakuza, and within three steps it's 78% against 62%. Both can reach every organization in seven steps, so the network is a small world either way, but the Sinaloa Cartel sits much closer to the middle of it. That's the practical meaning of a high eigenvector score.

1.9 Active vs. defunct organizations

The second categorical variable splits organizations into active and defunct. This is a two-group comparison, so it fits the t-test suggested in the assignment. I use **Welch's t-test**, which doesn't assume equal variances, and back it up with a Mann–Whitney test because of the skew. The 15 organizations whose status is unknown are left out of this part.

```
         orgs  mean partners  median partners  mean degree  mean eigen  median␣
 ↪eigen
status
Active    508         5.6575              3.0       0.0086      0.0210        0.
 ↪0085
Defunct   136         4.3529              3.0       0.0066      0.0203        0.
 ↪0106
Unknown    15         2.5333              2.0       0.0039      0.0038        0.
 ↪0018
```

```
                        active mean  defunct mean  Welch t  Welch p  M-W p
Cohen's d
measure
degree_centrality            0.0086        0.0066     2.49    0.013  0.050
0.21
eigenvector_centrality       0.0210        0.0203     0.26    0.798  0.125
0.02
```

1.10 Seeing the network



1.11 Findings

(Every number below comes from the outputs above.)

Popularity is spread fairly evenly across regions, but influence is not. The median organization has 2 or 3 partners in every region, and the Kruskal–Wallis test finds no significant difference in degree centrality between regions ($p = 0.14$). Eigenvector centrality is a different story ($p < 0.001$), and the Americas dominate. North American and Latin American organizations score significantly higher than organizations from every other region, and they don't differ significantly from each other. Europe makes up 36% of the organizations but only 10% of the eigenvector top 50, while North America and Latin America together hold 90% of it.

Why? Most cooperation stays inside a region (86% of ties), so the network has a few regional neighborhoods. The biggest and most connected one runs through the United States and Mexico: the Sinaloa Cartel, the Hells Angels, the American Mafia families and the Mexican cartels are all tied to each other. Being connected to that core is what drives eigenvector centrality up. About half of Latin America's ties outside the region (61 of 124) go to North American organizations. The Italian mafias are just as active by number of partners, but most of their ties are to other

Italian clans (16 of the Camorra's 27 partners and 21 of the Nuova Famiglia's 22 are Italian), so their influence stays local.

Who would you target? If the goal were to disrupt criminal cooperation, the two lists point to two different kinds of target. The organizations at the top of both lists (Sinaloa, the Hells Angels, the 'Ndrangheta, the American Mafia) are the obvious hubs. The eigenvector-only names like the Detroit Partnership or the Tijuana Cartel are the quieter ones. They aren't the most connected, but they are tied directly to the hubs, which is the same "guilt by association" idea used in fraud detection.

Active vs. defunct. Active organizations have more partners on average, and Welch's t-test says that difference is significant at the 5% level, but the Mann–Whitney test sits right on the line and the effect size is small. For eigenvector centrality there's no difference at all. Organizations CRIMENET lists as defunct, like Los Zetas (rank 9) and the Cali and Medellín cartels, still sit close to the hubs, because the network keeps every documented relationship regardless of when it happened.

1.12 Limitations

- **Wikipedia coverage.** An organization only appears if Wikipedia writes about it, and English, Italian, Spanish and Portuguese articles cover the Americas and Italy far better than Asia or Africa. Some of the regional gap could come from coverage, not from real differences in cooperation.
- **Extracted by an LLM.** The relationships were pulled out of text by a language model. Every edge has a supporting quote, but some could still be misclassified.
- **Ties across time.** The network combines relationships from different decades, so two organizations can be connected even if they were never active at the same time.
- **Mention-only organizations removed.** Dropping them (they have no country) lowers some degrees and leaves 63 organizations outside the largest group.
- **Splitting into units.** Italian clans and American Mafia families are separate nodes, while some other organizations are single large nodes. That affects how many organizations each region has.

1.13 References

- Franco Martins, A. (2026). *CRIMENET: Knowledge Graph of Global Organized Crime.* https://github.com/alvarofrancomartins/CRIMENET (commit `5b4a897`).
- Tsvetovat, M. and Kouznetsov, A. (2011). *Social Network Analysis for Startups.* O'Reilly Media.